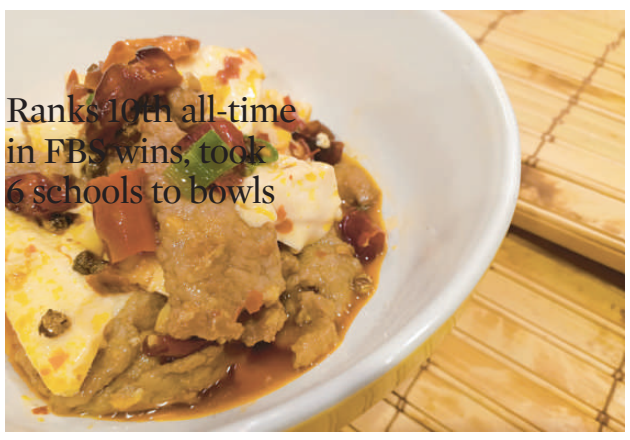
Orlando Sentinel FOODIE AWARDS

Amy Drew Thompson | ORLANDO SENTINEL



Beef fillets with tofu pudding from Yummy Taste. A favorite from the way-back that still hits.
AMY DREW THOMPSON/ORLANDO SENTINEL

BEST CHINESE
CRITIC'S CHOICE: YUMMY TASTE

The phrase about never being able to go home again hits me hard in my professional life. Chasing down new and new-to-me finds takes up most of my bandwidth. But recently, I had the chance to head back to a place I reviewed about four years ago and was happy to find that it hadn't changed much. The food? Still Sichuan and still excellent. The service? Still friendly. The decor? Near exactly the same (they never much remodeled after taking the space over from VLC Vegan Eatery back in the day), but there were some nice new tables and chairs in the mix. I generally take out, but it's always solid when it hits the table, hot and sizzling (or steaming in the case of my favorite soup- and stew-like dishes.

If you haven't visited before, you should. It's another fine example of wonderful cuisine from a humble family restaurant hiding out in the 'burbs. In this case, that's Waterford Lakes.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Yummy Taste, 504 N. Alafaya Trail in Orlando; 407-866-2199; yummytasteorlando.com
Runners-up:
- Spicy Girl in Orlando
- Green House Chinese Restaurant in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Taste of Chengdu, 2030 W. Colonial Drive in Orlando, 407-839-1983; tasteofchengduorlando.com
Runners-up:
- Yummy House in Altamonte Springs
- China Brothers in Orlando

Marie Mercado shows off an ube milkshake, at Sampaguita.
RICARDO RAMIREZ BUXEDA/ ORLANDO SENTINEL

BEST DESSERT
CRITIC'S CHOICE: SAMPAGUITA ICE CREAM + BAKESHOP

As usual, Orlandoans were divided on the recent cold snap. Some, donning boots and hats and jackets, found it glorious. Others, shivering as they paid the astronomical heating bills, found it ghastly. But soon we'll be well over the hump of such outliers and well into the season of sweat, and when that happens, few desserts hit as hard as Sampaguita's frosty halo halo, which owner Marie Mercado believes is a dessert everyone should enjoy. And that's why they offer an entirely vegan one, as well. There are other plant-based goodies here, and also lots and lots of delicious dairy. And some delicious house-baked desserts of the non-ice cream variety, as well. Don't be surprised if there's a line. Also, don't skip it if there is one. This place is worth the wait.

About a five-minute stroll from here is Koko Kakigori, where the Japanese shave ice is so light and fluffy, it seems likely to float away if not for the beautiful, handmade ceramic dishes that ground it. And literally steps from here, sits Kaya, a former Orlando Sentinel Foodie Awards Restaurant of the Year. A Michelin- and James Beard-recognized community gem. And the place where pastry pro Clarice Lam recently landed, upping not only their dessert game tenfold, but their Saturday morning coffee-and-pastry party: Kape Kaya (9:30 a.m. to noon or sellout). This coffee party is first-come, first-served. Guests are welcome to hang out and eat in the dining room or outside, or grab their goodies and go.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Sampaguita Ice Cream + Bakeshop, 1233 E. Colonial Drive in Orlando, sampaguitausa.com
Runners-up:
- Koko Kakigori in Orlando
- Kaya in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: The Glass Knife, 276 S. Orlando Ave. in Winter Park or 212 N. Park Ave. in Winter Park; theglassknife.com
Runners-up:
- Bernie's Gourmet to Go in Oviedo
- Bull & Bear in Orlando

BEST COFFEE
CRITIC'S CHOICE: EASY LUCK COFFEE & BODEGA

I joke a lot about coffee "beverages" and how it seems like most people in coffee shops don't actually want to drink coffee. From my observations of all the beautiful drinks, hot and cold, I see pro baristas crafting, and it's probably true.

But, really, who cares? Give the people what they want.

And while I'm marveling at the vanilla cola cold brews and pomegranate silan tonics and the sheer number of alternative milk options available these days, I can sip on my drip or pour over, made from thoughtfully curated beans, and be grateful I live in the city where Easy Luck Coffee & Bodega operates.

I love this bright space, which has everything I want in a coffee shop: solid pours and a knowledgeable staff, a wonderful menu for all kinds of eaters, ample working space, good music, and a cozy feel that reminds me of my Bohemian aunt's spacious, pre-war Brooklyn apartment. And when I'm ready to slam the laptop shut, they've got beer and natural wine to ease me out of work mode.

Downtown's Stemma features family-farmed coffee and some exceptional bites, while newcomer Águila in the Ivanhood is a friendly and promising shop with a delicious Guajillo-cayenne-spiced mocha and a gorgeous prime location across from the lake and steps from everything the neighborhood offers.

Avo toast, pickled onions and a beverage at Easy Luck Coffee & Bodega. LISA WILK/TASTECOOKSIP.COM

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Easy Luck Coffee & Bodega, 2425 E. S. St. in Orlando; 2425 E. South St. in Orlando
Runners-up:
- Águila Coffee in Orlando
- Stemma Craft Coffee in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Foxtail Coffee, multiple locations; foxtailcoffee.com
Runners-up:
- Park Avenue Cafe in Orlando
- Black Phin Coffee Bar in Winter Park

Chef Barbara Martinez of Cubans on Wheels credits much of her cooking prowess to her mother and grandmother, who ran a little kitchen back in her home of Guanabacoa, a township in eastern Havana.
AMY DREW THOMPSON/ORLANDO SENTINEL

BEST CUBAN
CRITIC'S CHOICE: CUBANS ON WHEELS

Still holding firm as my favorite for Cuban food, chef Barbara Martinez's Cubans on Wheels delivers everything one might want in the experience: abuelita-level portions, love and flavor. Also, the cute "patio" setup off her perma-parked food truck delivers Miami cafe vibes. There is no better or more convenient meal stop, either, before or after an MCO flight. Say yes to anything that sounds good. Recommendations include that massive Cuban sandwich and Martinez's stellar ropa vieja.

For traditional Cuban with a cheffy twist, find the folks at A Lo Cubano Kitchen inside the Great Southern Box Co. food hall, where you could roll with chef Yojan Gonzalez's tender ropa vieja, or lean hard into pork done two ways (belly y chicharrones!), or go off the reservation with a taco take through a Cuban filter.

Grab a pocket Cuban (it's an empanada) from The Gnarly Cuban's ventanita. Or housemade pastelitos. Or pan de mantequilla. And yes, of course, you definitely need a cortadito. They've got breakfasty things. They've got bowl-sized things. They've got lots of things. Find your Cuban bliss when you go see them.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Cubans on Wheels, 5749 TG Lee Blvd. in Orlando; facebook.com/Cubansonwheel2022
Runners-up:
- A Lo Cubano Kitchen in Orlando
- The Gnarly Cuban in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Black Bean Deli, 1346 N. Orange Ave. in Winter Park, 407-628-0294; blackbeandeli.com
Runners-up:
- Zaza Cuban Comfort Food, multiple locations
- Cubans On Wheels in Orlando

Red-eye gravy simmering on the stove top at what was then-Doug and Lil's Potato Patch in DeLand. It's still on the menu as the diner enters its new chapter as The Potato Patch, where just about everything but the ownership remains the same.
COURTESY DOUG & LIL'S POTATO PATCH

BEST DINER
CRITIC'S CHOICE: THE POTATO PATCH

Fans who've not been to Doug and Lil's Potato Patch in DeLand for some time will be surprised by the following recent development: it is no longer Doug and Lil's. That said, The Potato Patch's new chapter, one in which the new ownership is keeping the staff, the system, the recipes and all the things folks love about this little country diner firmly in place, seems evident.

For those of you new to the area, or headed to or from the coast in the direction of DeLand, if you're looking for a cozy, quaint, 'n' homey spot for Southern diner classics, you couldn't do better. Just make sure you bring cash. No cards here.

Closer to home, Dixie Belle's Cafe has offered home-style country cooking for nearly 20 years here in Orlando, while newcomer Moa Kai in Mills 50 is two-scooping out rice, Hawaiian-style (which means "one scoop mac" to go with) with aloha-infused classics that Zippy's fans will surely dig.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: The Potato Patch, 635 S. Woodland Blvd. in DeLand, 386-734-8181; facebook.com/potatopatch
Runners-up:
- Dixie Belle's Cafe in Orlando
- Moa Kai Hawaiian Diner in Orlando

READERS' CHOICE
Winner: Johnny's Diner, 3335 Curryford Road in Orlando, 407-868-8267; johnnysdiner.co
Runners-up:
- The Town House Restaurant in Oviedo
- Dixie Belle's Cafe in Orlando

BEST DOUGHNUTS
CRITIC'S CHOICE: DONUT KING

I love simplicity when it comes to doughnuts. Simple cakey confections like Donut King's almond crunch, chocolate glazed or blueberry cake with a cup of coffee are sweet-snack perfection. Then there are the maple-bacon bar days. Those are very, very good days.

For the ones when you're looking for something elegant, The Glass Knife (now with two Winter Park locations!) has got you covered with all manner of beautiful, creative specimens (though the blissfully filled brioche of their crème brulee offering is probably my favorite filled doughnut in town). And if you're going over-the-top, The Salty's titanic takes (some are even gluten-free!) may be right up your alley.

CRITIC'S CHOICE
Winner: Donut King, locations in Leesburg, Minneola and Winter Park; thedonutking.com
Runners-up:
- The Glass Knife in Winter Park
- The Salty in Orlando

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So many Donut King doughnuts, so little time. Especially if you eat too many doughnuts. But what a way to go!
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